FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

From Maharashtra to the Mahabharata. The BJP's coup in Maharashtra, in diminishing the NCP just nine days after the big Opposition meet in Patna, meant that the battle for the 2024 general election had truly begun. The BJP had won 303 seats on its own—353 with the NDA—in 2019. India's savviest party is well aware it cannot scale such Himalayan peaks again just by usual electioneering. Altered equations make it imperative for the BJP to play no holds barred to achieve three goals: ensuring Prime Minister Narendra Modi gets a record third term, guaranteeing a majority on its own so as not to depend on allies, and opening up new territories. For this, it has identified six or seven key states rich in numbers and political capital. Consequently, they have unleashed simultaneous hostilities on multiple flanks, taking the battering ram right into enemy territory. We are calling it 'Operation Demolition'.

Its own turf has to be protected first. Uttar Pradesh looms the biggest of them all. It cannot afford even a slight drop from its 62/80 score there, but this is also comparatively its least daunting challenge. Isolating Akhilesh Yadav, not letting him create a force-multiplying latticework with floating 3-4 per cent vote bloc fragments, is the game. Not loosening the leash on Mayawati, winning over his pals like Jayant Chaudhary of the RLD and sewing up mobile small parties should suffice. Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh, states which the BJP made a near-clean sweep of, had to be immunised against any erosion. But the real focus is on the other big states that yielded a bumper harvest in 2019. Just a month ago, the BJP was staring at a cheerless picture everywhere. Take just four. The saffron alliance had won 41 of the 48 Lok Sabha seats in Maharashtra, but the Shiv Sena accounted for 18 of those. And the JD(U)'s 16 seats were a key component of its near-sweep of 39/40 in Bihar. Those two key allies have decamped. The BJP itself had secured 25/28 in Karnataka, but the state has seen a Congress resurgence. In West Bengal, they won a commendable 18 out of 42 seats, but seem to have lost momentum. In this week's panchayat polls, they got only 220 out of 3,317 gram panchayats, six out of 341 panchayat samitis and zero zilla parishads.



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Meanwhile, the Opposition is busily crafting a grand half-crescent of all anti-BJP forces. They had a pilot run of the prototype at Patna on June 23, where 15 parties came together, and are meeting again in a week's time in Bengaluru. Their basic calculation is: they had scored a mere 154 seats against the BJP's 303, despite having 1.57 million more votes than the BJP's 229 million, only because they contested against each other. What if they closed ranks and made it 'two plus two five'? The spectre of a whole greater than the sum of its parts must have spooked the BJP. Having already maxed out in Gujarat and other strongholds, it had to indemnify itself against potential haemorrhage. It was time for a surgical strike on the Opposition to unsettle them.

What better place than Maharashtra, where they had already drawn first blood by splitting the Shiv Sena last year. Stack together the 2019 votes of the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) consisting the NCP, Congress and Sena: a formidable 55 per cent. The hard-won split in the Sena hadn't eased the heartache from that soured ideological love affair. Besides, they probably reckoned current chief minister Eknath Shinde and his ragtag horsemen couldn't be the vanguard for a Lok Sabha battle. That's what could have catalysed Part II of Operation Lotus. The NCP itself had to be broken. Prising away the ambitious Ajit Pawar, plus Praful Patel, the trusted aide of strongman Sharad Pawar, and a cohort of MLAs accomplished that. Also, it humiliated Pawar, the elder statesman of Opposition unity, and has left the MVA completely disoriented.

Bihar, the original laboratory of 'mahagathbandhans', was next. In 2019, the NDA had 53 per cent of the vote share and RJD+ just shy of 31 per cent. But adjust for the JD(U)'s 21.8 per cent and the pendulum careens the other way. Hence, the pincer attack. Tense ground battles were already on to cut friend-turned-bugbear Nitish Kumar down to size. Jitan Ram Manjhi's HAM was weaned away, and talk was that the BJP may do an NCP on the JD(U). Even as Nitish went into emergency confabulations with his legislators, there came the aerial strikes: a CBI chargesheet against deputy CM Tejashwi Yadav, and his parents Lalu Yadav and Rabri Devi. The BJP is hammering in the point that Lalu's legal troubles owe entirely to the JD(U)'s old campaign against him. That same Damocles's sword dangles on Mamata Banerjee's TMC too, with her second-in-command and nephew Abhishek being the target to dent the party.

In Karnataka, with the Congress now in power, retaining its phenomenal 2019 score of 25/28 will be a challenge. So, it's cosying up to the mercurial JD(S): together, they can sew up the crucial Old Mysuru region and cut any possible overall losses. The BJP also can't afford to let any Congress gain disturb neighbouring Telangana. The appearance of that common foe has coaxed the BJP and K. Chandrashekar Rao's BRS, otherwise engaged in a mortal duel, into making common cause. The BRS, again with an ED case dangling against the CM's daughter Kalvakuntla Kavitha, will take on the outsourced job of stamping out any Congress revival even as new state BJP chief G. Kishan Reddy ploughs his own field. A more daring sortie may be into Tamil Nadu, where the saffron party is keen to finally emerge out of the Dravidian shadow. Discrediting the DMK, as with the Senthil Balaji case, is key to making inroads into the deepest part of the Deccan. The political earthquake in Maharashtra, then, is meant to spread. One can expect many fissures and upheavals in India's political landscape in the coming months. In an interview to Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa and Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan, BJP president J.P. Nadda defended his party against the charge that it is engineering the defections. "In Maharashtra, it was the NCP that had internal differences, Ajit Pawar and others came on their own volition believing they could serve the nation better by joining forces with the BJP," he said. "We have not compromised our ideology by welcoming them."

In this week's cover story, our reporters from all bureaus trace the full cartography of the BJP's game plan to defang the Opposition in key states long before the Lok Sabha polls in May 2024. What the electorate makes of all these machinations we will find out only then.

(Aroon Purie)